

Put the Team Before Yourself: Carrots and Sticks, Featuring Virginia Means

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“It’s all about perception. And if teammates find you the least bit inconsistent, moody, unpredictable, indecisive, or emotionally unreliable, then they balk. And the whole team is destabilized.”

This is a stick. It’s a fine stick. It’s a strong stick. And let’s say it’s your stick. But here’s the reality. Somebody will always have a bigger stick. And this stick is larger, more powerful. You can do more, both good and bad, with this stick.

Usually, the person with this stick is the team leader or the departmental manager. And with this stick comes great power. Let’s face it, some people love to have the bigger stick and remind people of that power.

So, here’s a question. Which is bigger? Power or authority? Power uses the big stick to compel a desired behavior but can damage relationships in the process. It’s using the big stick to poke, prod, scare the team members into shape. It’s using the power of intimidation. Hey, look, I’ve got this big stick to get people to do things. It’s leading from behind, like herding them. But here’s the reality. You cannot lead from behind.

Authority is different. Authority is achieving a desired behavior through influence. It’s leading from the front. It’s having the bigger stick, but not having to use it. People are compelled, even inspired to follow you when you have the bigger stick because you’re helpful. You’re real. You’re approachable. You coach. You don’t intimidate. You put the needs of the team before yourself.

If you know anything at all about Pat Summitt, you know she had authority and she was an expert on how to influence her team to work hard, play together, and commit to a larger goal. As Pat said, “Teamwork is taught. You don’t just lump a group of people together in a room and call them a team and expect them to behave like one.”

Like Pat, there will be times in your career when you have the biggest stick in the room, and you’ll have to ask yourself, “Am I going to rely on the stick or am I going to rely on me and my character to lead this team?” Don’t let this get in the way of you leading from the correct position, from the front with authentic authority.